

The 10 Identity Fabric Principles That Prepare IAM for the Future

Erik Wahlström

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Hidden complexity

A close-up, high-magnification photograph of a microchip or semiconductor device. The surface is covered in a dense grid of small, circular, orange-gold features, likely solder bumps or vias. Darker, rectangular structures are visible, representing various components or pads on the chip. The lighting creates a slight gradient, with the top appearing slightly darker than the bottom.

It is neither possible nor
reasonable to expect **everyone**
to be identity experts.



Zero-trust journeys require an **identity-first security** approach, and it must be powered by a **radically** modernized IAM infrastructure.

Agenda

1. Why is an identity fabric important now?
2. What principles should you be thinking about?
3. Where should you start?

The Big Picture of IAM



Users
Defined by an IAM taxonomy



Target systems



IAM controls

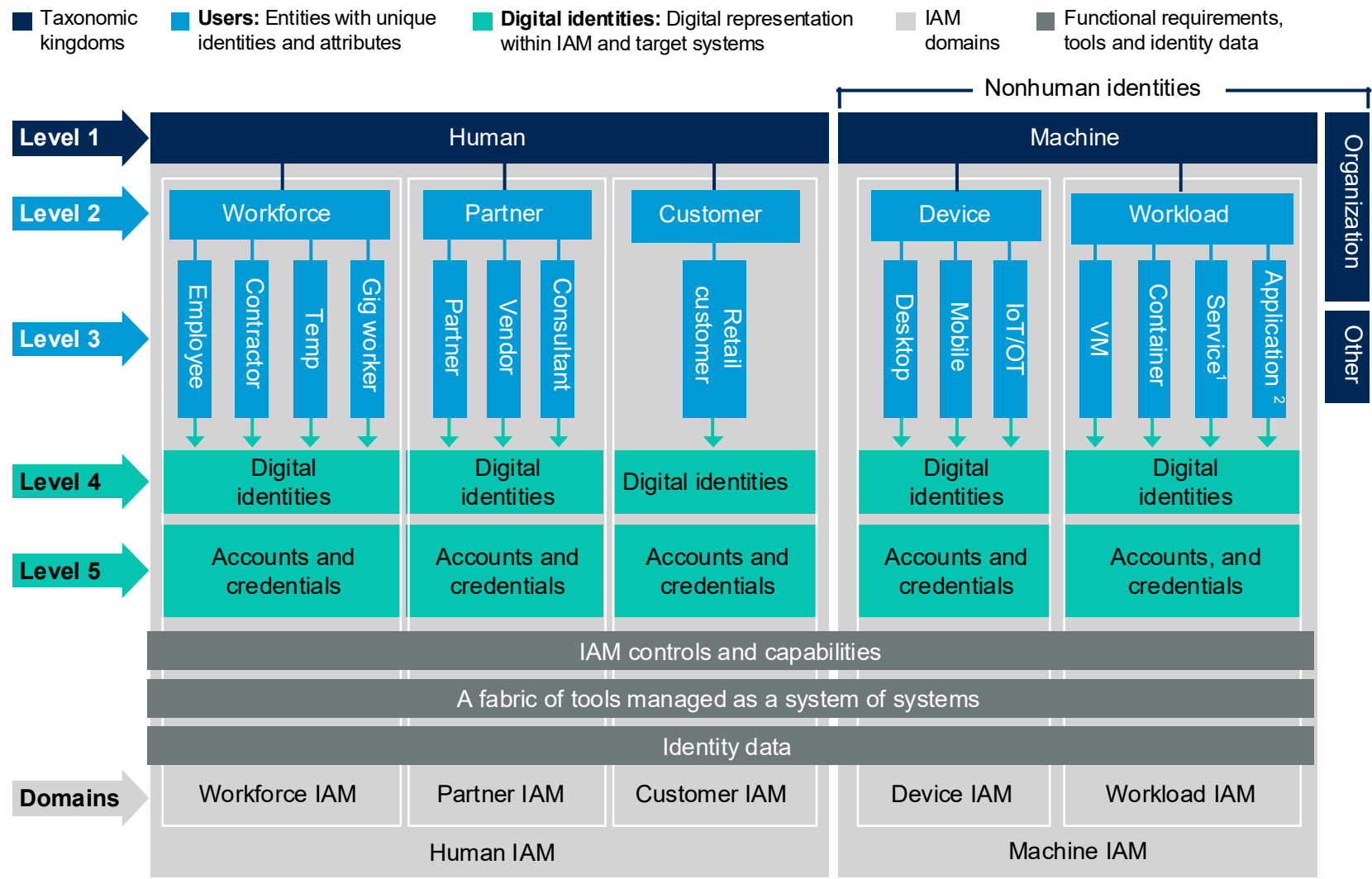


Identity fabric
Operating according to the 10 identity fabric principles



Identity data

The IAM Taxonomy



¹ web, REST, API, RPC, webhook

² web, native, script, service, RPA, AI agent

The Big Picture of IAM



Users

Defined by an IAM taxonomy



Target systems



IAM controls



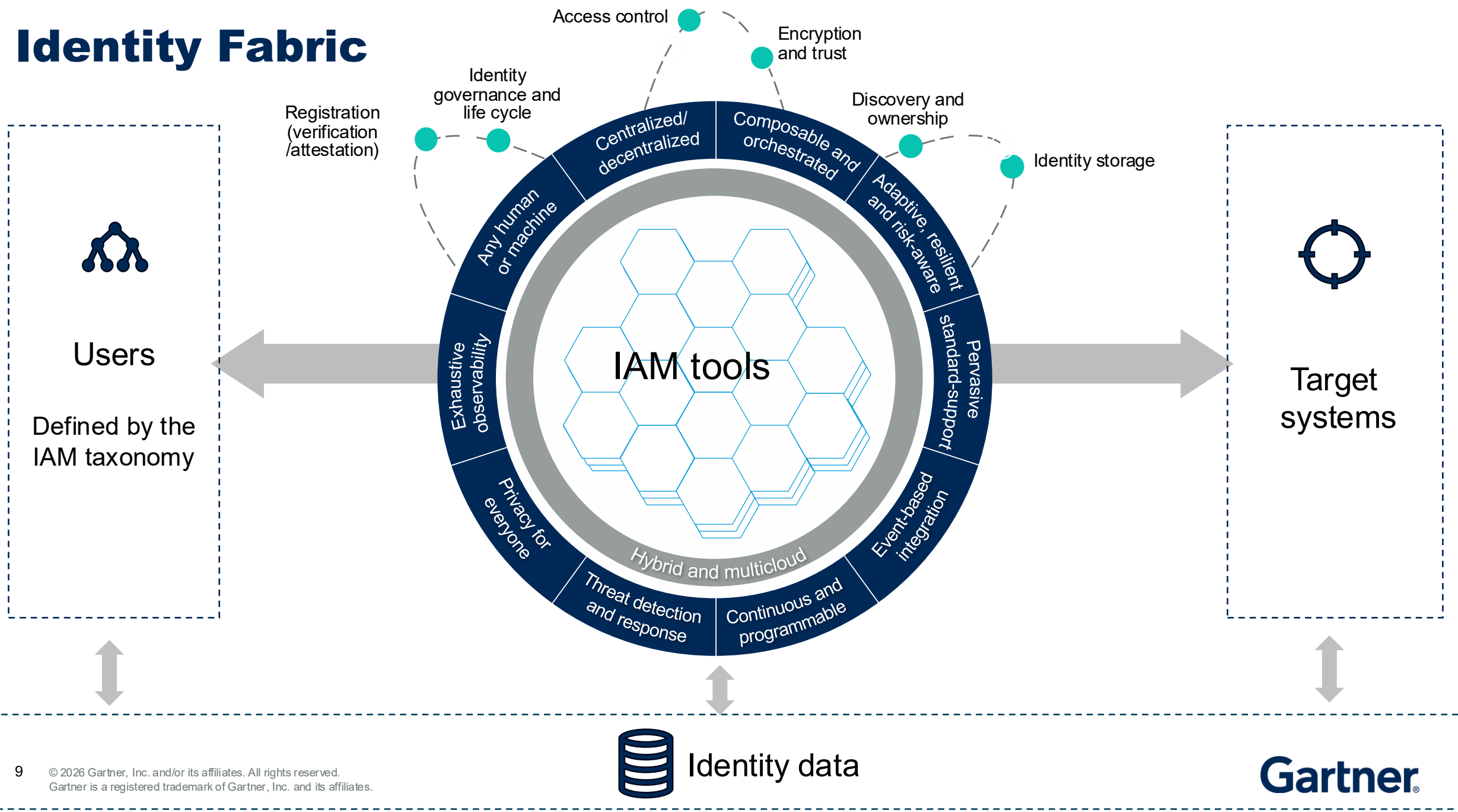
Identity fabric

Operating according to the 10 identity fabric principles

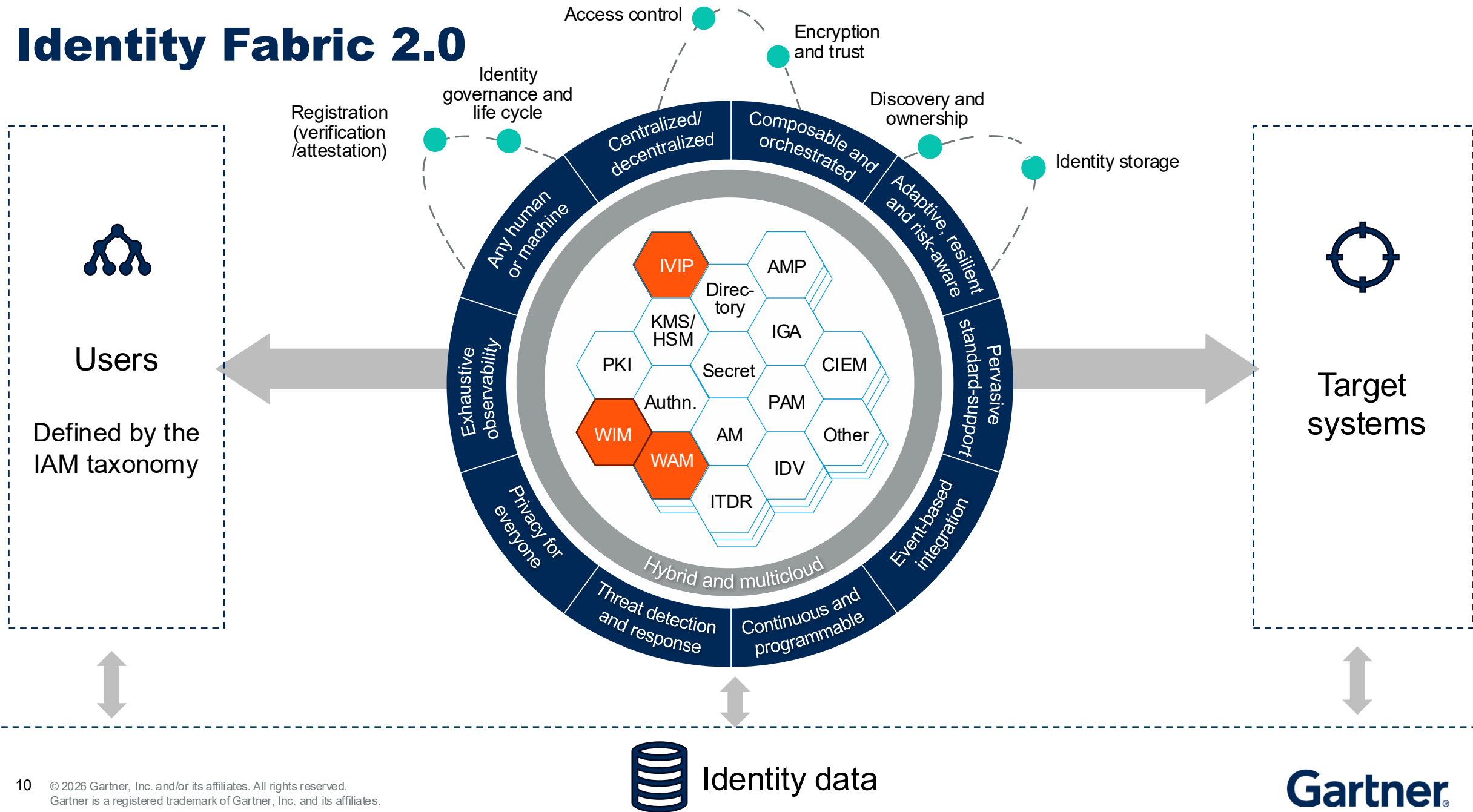


Identity data

Identity Fabric



Identity Fabric 2.0



Identity data

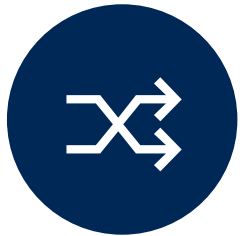
Identity Fabric Myths



An identity fabric is a product.



All IAM tool duplication should be eliminated.



An identity fabric requires consolidating security domains.



You need to rip and replace to create an identity fabric.



An identity fabric is an IAM infrastructure built on the key identity fabric principles to enable business and security identity-first strategies.

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The 10 Identity Principles

	Traditional IAM principles	Modern IAM principles	Identity fabric principles
Scope	Organizational only		
Topology	Siloed		
Architecture	Closed, proprietary connectors		
Security	Physical		
Standards	Few		
Connectivity	Siloed		
Change	Periodic		
Threat detection and response	None		
Privacy preserving	None		
Observability	None		

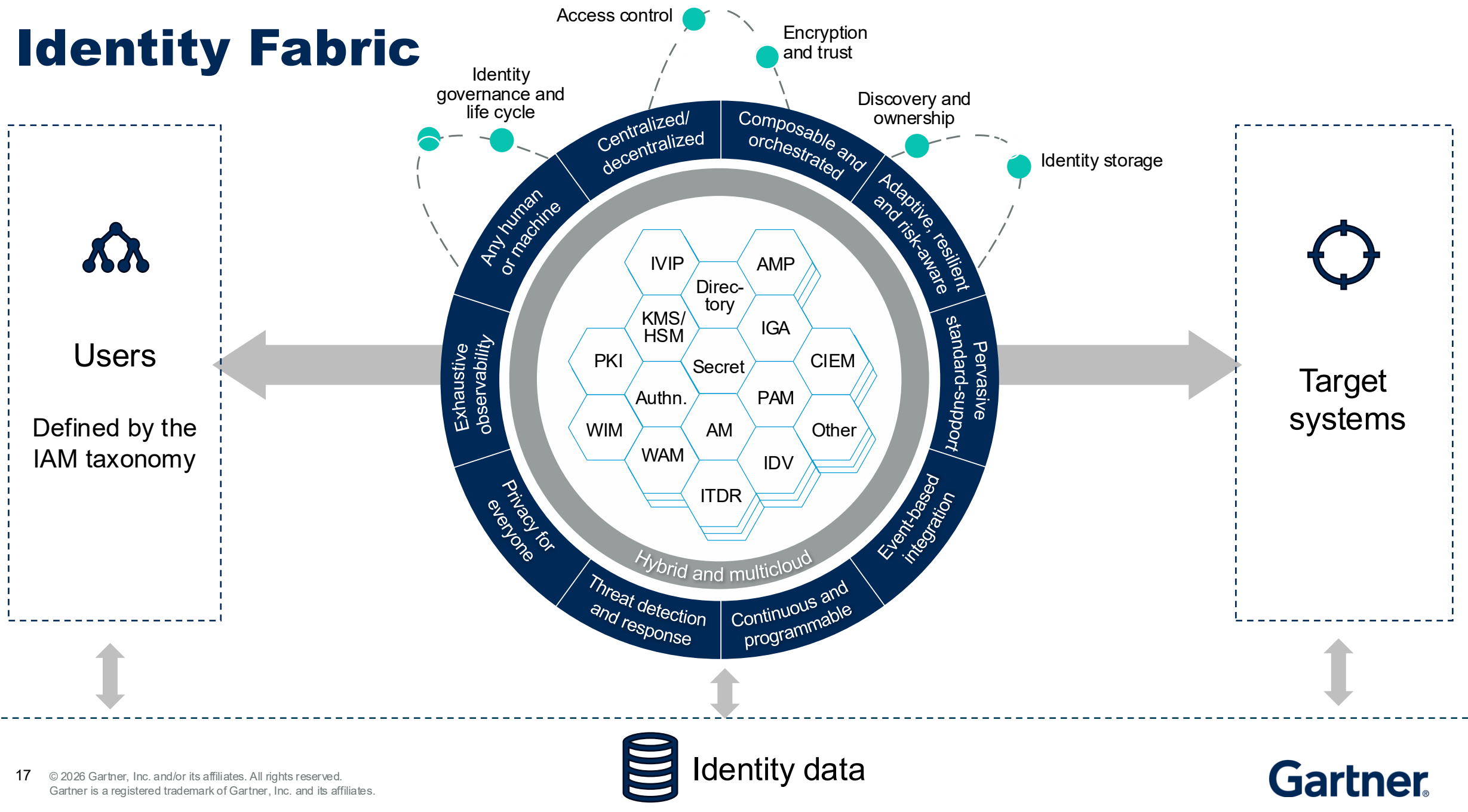
The 10 Identity Principles

	Traditional IAM principles	Modern IAM principles	Identity fabric principles
Scope	Organizational only	Multiple organizations and the public	
Topology	Siloed	Centralized	
Architecture	Closed, proprietary connectors	Extensible and interoperable	
Security	Physical	Logical	
Standards	Few	Some	
Connectivity	Siloed	Pull-based integration	
Change	Periodic	Frequent	
Threat detection and response	None	Descriptive	
Privacy preserving	None	For customers in selected regions	
Observability	None	Discovery in siloes	

The 10 Identity Principles

	Traditional IAM principles	Modern IAM principles	Identity fabric principles
Scope	Organizational only	Multiple organizations and the public	Any human or machine
Topology	Siloed	Centralized	Centralized control and decentralized enforcement
Architecture	Closed, proprietary connectors	Extensible and interoperable	Composable and orchestrated
Security	Physical	Logical	Adaptive, resilient, and risk-aware
Standards	Few	Some	Pervasive standard-support
Connectivity	Siloed	Pull-based integration	Event-based integration
Change	Periodic	Frequent	Continuous and programmable
Threat detection and response	None	Descriptive	Prescriptive with remediation
Privacy preserving	None	For customers in selected regions	For everyone
Observability	None	Discovery in siloes	Exhaustive observability

Identity Fabric

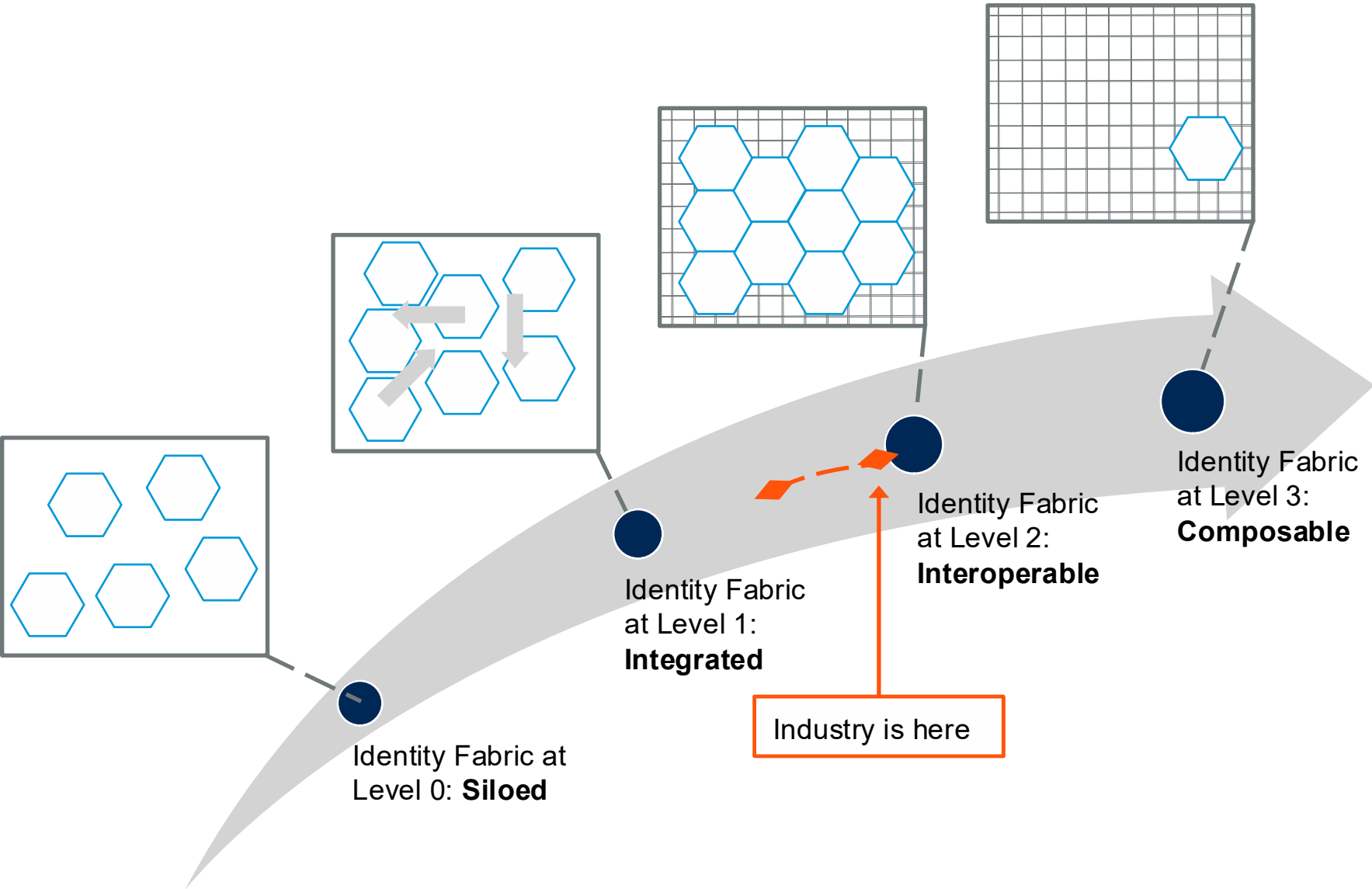


Every Organization Has an IAM Infrastructure

Some IAM infrastructures are more fabric like and modern than others.



Identity Fabric Maturity Model





Use the 10 identity fabric principles and the Gartner IAM taxonomy to guide the evolution of your existing IAM infrastructure into a more connected identity fabric.

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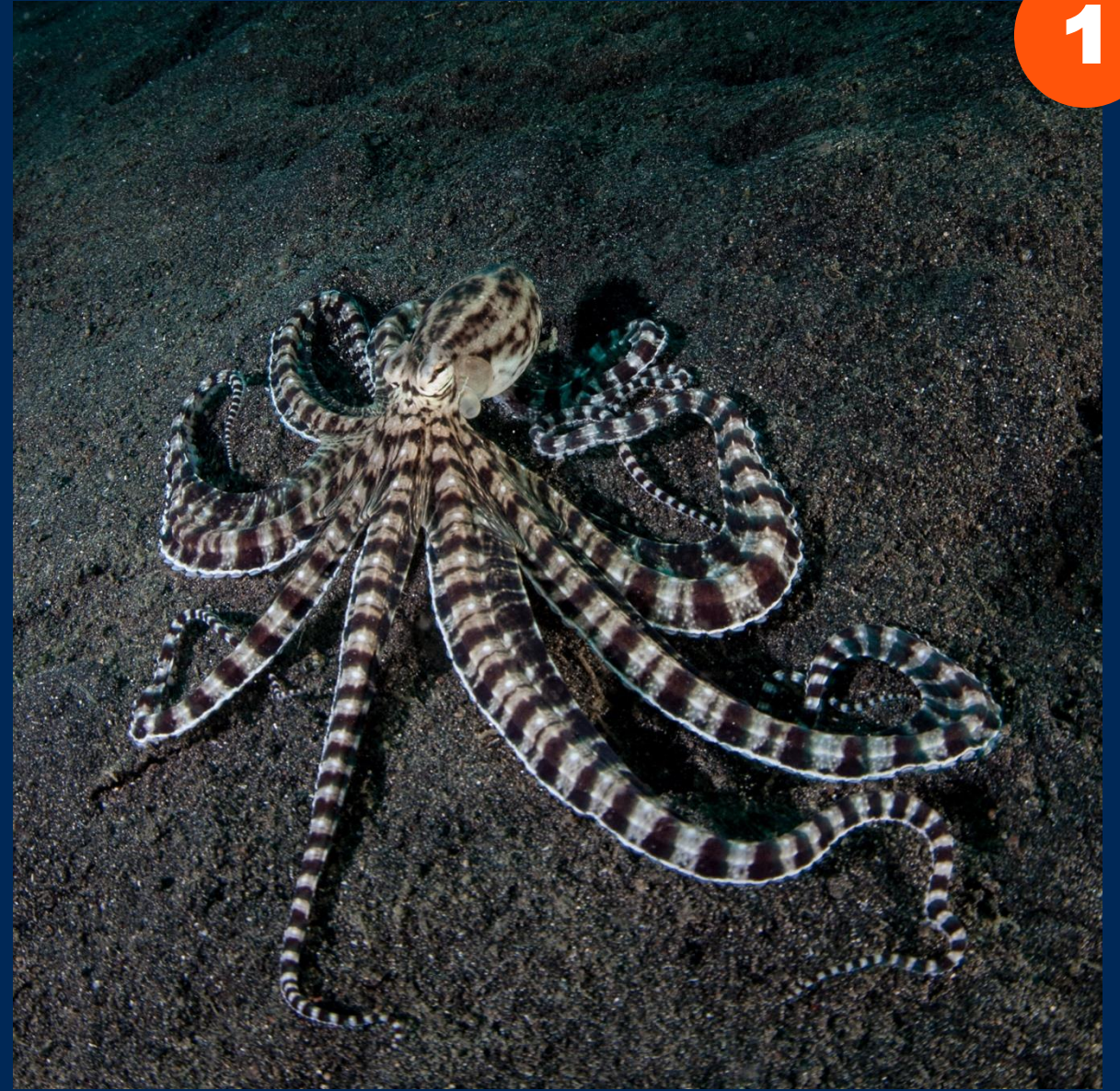
6 Steps to Evolve IAM Into an Identity Fabric

1. Define best-of-breed and all-in-one strategies
2. Leverage modern identity protocols and standards
3. Manage the identity fabric using identity-as-code
4. Protect your identity fabric with identity threat detection and response
5. Resolve IAM technical debt and expand the reach of the identity fabric
6. Strengthen identity data strategies

Best-of-breed or all-in-one?

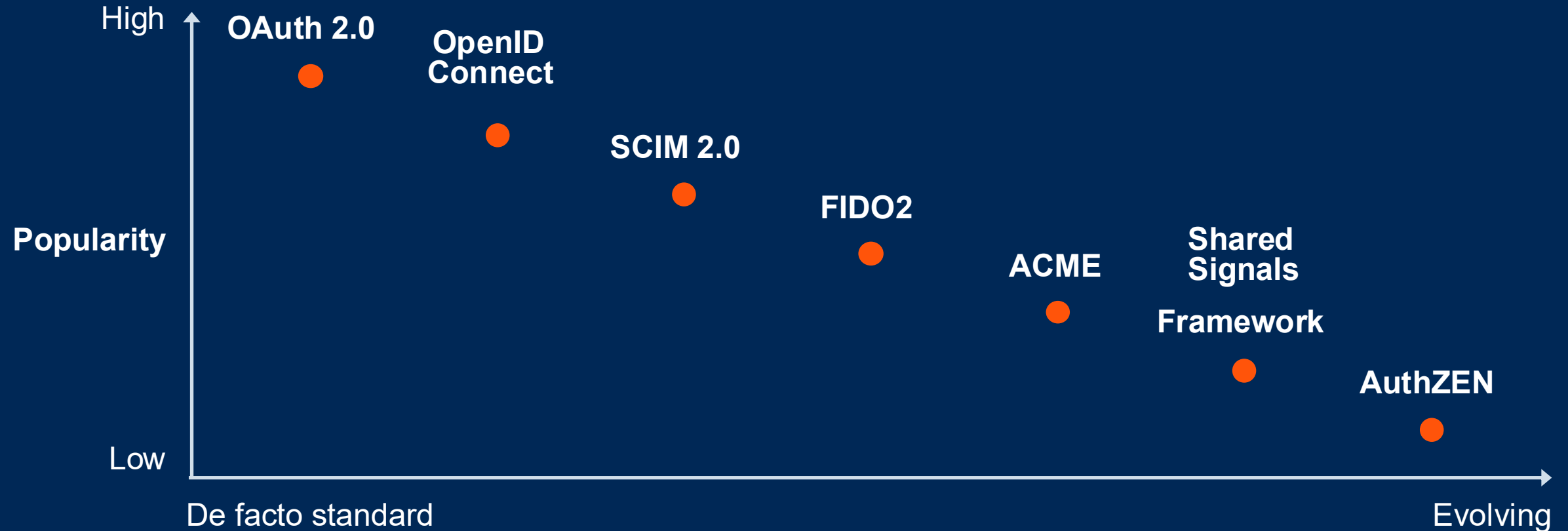
Invest or manage cost?

Apply **Centralized/ Decentralized Security** Best Practices to Your IAM Architecture



Must-Have IAM Requirements for Enterprise Applications

2

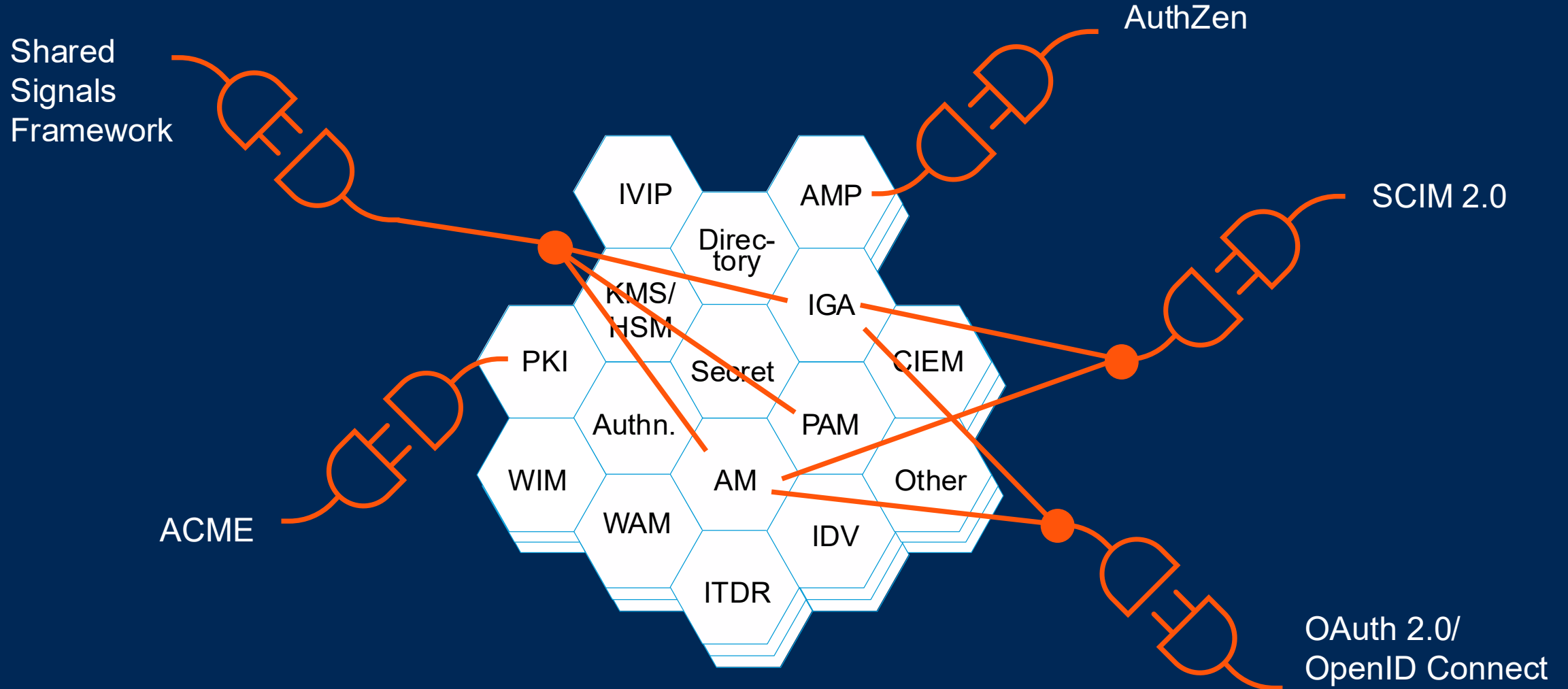


Source: Gartner

ACME = Automated Certificate Management Environment; FIDO2 = Fast Identity Online 2; SCIM = System for Cross-Domain Identity Management

Must-Have IAM Requirements for Enterprise Applications

2



Must-Have IAM Requirements for Enterprise Applications

2



IPSIE

SCIM 2.0

Shared Signals Framework

OAuth 2.0/OpenID Connect

ACME

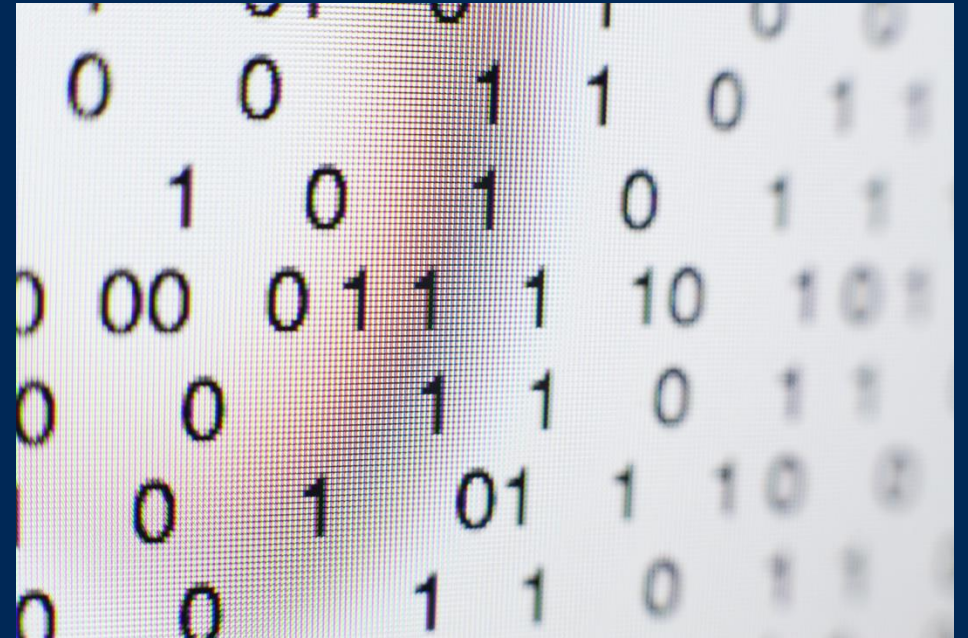
AuthZen

Manage the Identity Fabric Using Identity-as-Code (IDaC)

3



IDaC



Protect your identity fabric with identity threat detection and response

Resolve IAM technical debt and expand the reach of the identity fabric

Fix last-mile issues using “glueware”

Strengthen Identity Data Strategies

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Recommendations

- ④ **Future**-proof your IAM by adopting the 10 principles.
- ④ **Evolve** your IAM deployment using the Gartner IAM taxonomy into a flexible, **cohesive** system as part of an ongoing IAM program.
- ④ **Begin** with use cases and focus on IAM controls — don't try to do everything at once and use existing tools.
- ④ **Revisit** your architecture to validate that it meets current needs.
- ④ **Use** identity data to share more context between security and identity tools.
- ④ **Leverage** zero-trust and cloud migration projects to obtain resources.

Recommended Gartner Research

To learn more about access to Gartner research, expert analyst insight, and peer communities, contact your Gartner representative or click on “Become A Client” on gartner.com to speak with one of our specialists.

- 🔍 [Evolve IAM Using 10 Identity Fabric Principles](#)
Erik Wahlstrom and Mary Ruddy
- 🔍 [IAM — Taxonomy, Domains and Tooling](#)
Erik Wahlstrom
- 🔍 [2026 Planning Guide for Identity and Access Management](#)
Erik Wahlstrom, Mary Ruddy and Others
- 🔍 [Reduce IAM Technical Debt](#)
Nat Krishnan and Erik Wahlstrom
- 🔍 [The Must-Have IAM Requirements for Enterprise Applications](#)
Mehmet Yaliman and Erik Wahlstrom

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